



Implementing Entrepreneurial Mindset Culture Change

By Charles Almond, Charles F. Erickson Distinguished Chair of Entrepreneurship;
professor, Computer Technology, West Virginia University, Parkersburg, WV

Editor's Note: Following is the second installment in a two-part series.

Entering an entrepreneurial mindset throughout college curriculum benefits everyone but implementing a culture change in any organization can be a daunting task. Here are some recommendations for getting a plan in place.

Assess your Starting Point

This starts with identifying and evaluating each stakeholder or group of stakeholders. This will likely consist mostly of faculty members, but don't forget the staff and administration. As with any change, some people will be on board and see this as an opportunity, some will be indifferent, and some will be resistant. For each group, consider what support they may need to help them make this change. By creating support and resources ahead of time, you will be more likely to win them over.

There are two approaches to achieve change. First is the rational-empirical approach, in which you provide evidence that supports the benefits of the change. This approach is best used with stakeholders who have a positive view of adopting this mindset in their coursework. The second, the normative-reeducative strategy, focuses on how the change will benefit the institution and those around the stakeholder. This approach is best suited to stakeholders who are neutral or somewhat negative towards making these changes.

To be successful, consider which of the two approaches is best for each stakeholder or group of stakeholders, and develop a process to communicate and implement this change. This cultural change should align with the institution's mission and strategic plan, and that alignment should be clearly communicated to stakeholders. This is vital because it shows the alignment of this change with the current values of the organization.



Communication Is Key

Once stakeholders have been categorized, the next step is to develop a communication plan for each of them. Start with the goals (to create graduates who are problem solvers and independent thinkers), and explain for each stakeholder how this can relate to what they teach and how it might improve student learning. Try to personalize the positive outcomes for each stakeholder and remember that change doesn't have to happen all at once; it might begin with just one class or even one assignment.

Be ready to answer questions and listen to any concerns. As Stephen Covey writes in *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People*, seek first to understand, then to be understood. For anyone who is resistant to this change, it's vital that their concerns are heard and understood. One technique used in design thinking is to take a problem and

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restate it as a question, then answer the question to help identify a solution. Coaching, mentoring, and providing easy access to support and resources should be a top priority at this stage. The entrepreneurial leader should lead by example and share any resources and advice.



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Analyze the Data

Measuring success and failure is important. By agreeing on a way to assess students' success after adopting this new approach, you can quantitatively measure if students are doing better or worse. With that in mind, consider how to measure and communicate progress, and follow through. Share successes, failures, and lessons learned with all faculty to learn and improve. Follow up regularly to make sure things don't go "back to normal," and celebrate successes while treating failures as opportunities to improve. By applying the entrepreneurial mindset to this challenge, the people bringing about this change can overcome obstacles and achieve success. ●



Contact: charles.almond@WVUP.edu

Lightfoot says his second year is "a lot more work" than his first year at the Academy, as cadets dive deeper into preparation to be officers. Lightfoot's favorite part of the Verizon program was attending a three-day summit in San Francisco, where he and about 100 other students saw real-world applications of what they were learning. During the trip, Lightfoot and the other students toured the Verizon Innovation Lab and saw how STEM is used at a film and TV production company, among other STEM-focused activities.



Photo credit: Ross Oscar Knight

Lightfoot and other students from the Jackson State Verizon Innovative Learning program participated in various tours and experiences throughout their time in San Francisco.

"At the Verizon Innovation Lab, it was pretty cool seeing a robot balance a ball; it was showing future ideas," Lightfoot says. "We also saw the difference in internet speeds—3G, 4G and 5G. At the end of the trip, they gave us time to go out and explore. It was nice having the freedom to experience that at that age."

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After Verizon Innovative Learning, Lightfoot got more involved in other STEM camps, thanks to the support and encouragement of his family and family friends. "My family kept putting me and my cousin [who also attended the Verizon program] into different programs. That gave me early exposure to STEM and helped me stay interested in it after middle school," he says. "My family is very excited about what I'm doing now at the Academy."

In high school, Lightfoot continued his STEM journey through various activities, joining a robotics club and competing in the C Spire Coding Challenge. His dedication was recognized with a \$40,000 scholarship from a major tech company for students pursuing computer science or engineering. "I'm pretty tech savvy," he says. "My tech experience sets me apart." ●